

Summer Reading 2026

Incoming 12th Grade

Read with a purpose. Consider how the protagonist's journey — or the author's argument — illuminates broader societal questions, and what the challenges faced, moral dilemmas encountered, and transformative moments reveal.

FICTION

First-Year Orientation

Lauren Gibaldi & Eric Smith (eds.)

Short Stories, College Life

Uncommon Type

Tom Hanks

Short Stories, Literary Fiction

Americanah

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie

Realistic Fiction, Immigration, Nigeria

The Color Purple

Alice Walker

Historical Fiction, Feminism, Race

His Hideous Heart

Dahlia Adler (ed.)

Short Stories, Gothic, Horror

The Jasmine Project

Meredith Ireland

Contemporary Fiction, Romance

The Lowland

Jhumpa Lahiri

Historical Fiction, India, Family

Missionaries

Phil Klay

Historical Fiction, War, Colombia

Norse Mythology

Neil Gaiman

Mythology, Retelling

Parable of the Sower

Octavia E. Butler

Science Fiction, Dystopia

The Project

Courtney Summers

Thriller, Cult

Such a Fun Age

Kiley Reid

Realistic Fiction, Race

Tenth of December

George Saunders

Short Stories, Literary Fiction

Traveling Light

Lynne Branard

Contemporary Fiction, Road Trip

Malibu Rising

Taylor Jenkins Reid

Historical Fiction, Family

Warrior Girl Unearthed

Angeline Boulley

Thriller, Indigenous Fiction

The Bonesetter's Daughter

Amy Tan

Historical Fiction, China, Family

Firekeeper's Daughter

Angeline Boulley

Mystery, Thriller, Indigenous Fiction

The Invisible Life of Addie LaRue

V.E. Schwab

Fantasy, Romance

Little and Lion

Brandy Colbert

Realistic Fiction, LGBTQ+, Mental Health

Machine Man

Max Barry

Science Fiction, Humor

The Nickel Boys

Colson Whitehead

Historical Fiction, Civil Rights

Our Missing Hearts

Celeste Ng

Literary Fiction, Dystopia

Permanent Record

Mary H.K. Choi

Realistic Fiction, Romance

The Song of Achilles

Madeline Miller

Mythology, Historical Fiction, LGBTQ

Symptoms of Being Human

Jeff Garvin

Realistic Fiction, LGBTQ+

Tigers, Not Daughters

Samantha Mabry

Magical Realism, Family

The Vanishing Half

Brit Bennett

Realistic Fiction, Race, Family

We Are Okay

Nina LaCour

Realistic Fiction, LGBTQ+

The Good Immigrant

Nikesh Shukla (ed.)

Essays, Immigration

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NONFICTION

Victory. Stand!

Tommie Smith & Derrick Barnes

Graphic Memoir, Sports, Civil Rights

All You Can Ever Know

Nicole Chung

Memoir, Adoption, Identity

Blue Blood

Edward Conlon

Memoir, Law Enforcement

The Conservative Sensibility

George F. Will

Nonfiction, Politics, History

Dead Wake

Erik Larson

Narrative Nonfiction, History, WWI

Grass

Keum Suk Gendry-Kim

Graphic Novel, WWII, Korea

Hunger: A Memoir of My Body

Roxane Gay

Memoir, Body Image, Abuse

The Line Becomes a River

Francisco Cantú

Memoir, Immigration, Border

Outliers

Malcolm Gladwell

Nonfiction, Psychology, Success

Rise and Grind

Daymond John

Nonfiction, Business, Entrepreneurship

Slow Getting Up

Nate Jackson

Memoir, Football, Sports

We Are Not Yet Equal

Carol Anderson & Tonya Bolden

Narrative Nonfiction, Civil Rights, History

First to a Million

Dan Sheeks

Nonfiction, Personal Finance

21 Lessons for the 21st Century

Yuval Noah Harari

Nonfiction, Philosophy, Society

Blood, Sweat, and Pixels

Jason Schreier

Nonfiction, Technology, Gaming

Calypso

David Sedaris

Memoir, Humor, Family

The Cost of These Dreams

Wright Thompson

Essays, Sports, Biography

The Fall of the House of FIFA

David Conn

Nonfiction, Sports, Corruption

How I Built This

Guy Raz

Nonfiction, Entrepreneurship, Business

Into the Wild

Jon Krakauer

Narrative Nonfiction, Survival, Nature

Master Slave Husband Wife

Ilyon Woo

Narrative Nonfiction, History, Slavery

Presidential Courage

Michael R. Beschloss

Nonfiction, History, U.S. Presidents

The Short and Tragic Life of Robert Peace

Jeff Hobbs

Nonfiction, Biography

Stamped from the Beginning

Ibram X. Kendi

History, Race, Civil Rights

You Can't Touch My Hair

Phoebe Robinson

Essays, Humor, African American Women